



ATUL PRATAP CHAUHAN

tance of his, Neville Williams, who runs a non-profit solar lighting organisation in the US, asked him if he would like to start a project in India to light up 100 homes with solar lights. Hande, who hadn't completed his Ph.D then, decided to come back to India again. With the \$5,000, he decided to develop five or six demonstration projects. He gave himself a salary of Rs 1,000 a month. But the demonstrations didn't work. The audience, who weren't convinced that solar lighting was a great idea. So he hired a technician zeroed in on a somewhat educated betel nut farmer. One day, when the farmer went out to work, Hande installed a solar point system in his house with a television set. He went back a week later and the farmer was so happy with the system that he paid for the installation. Hande bought another system with the money and lit up another home.

There was a time when one of his customers said he couldn't give him money for lighting his house. At that time Hande and his two technicians realised that they had no money to travel back to Mangalore, where he was living with his aunt then. His technicians agreed to work as coolies for a few hours at the bus station to raise money for the fare. That incident made him realise that to make his business commercially viable, he had to get the funding agencies interested. He started approaching grameen banks and rural financial institutions, who gradually agreed to give loans to his customers. He got schools to install "light scholarships" where a school would install a system in a poor student's house if he or she did well in studies.

Right now, Hande's company has an annual turnover of Rs 13.5 crore, and he hopes to take it to Rs 40 crore by the end of the decade. His five-member management team and he still meet 500 customers each every year. He currently has 142, excluding many "technical assistants" in the villages who work on commission. He has tied up with the Massachusetts Institute of Technology to develop sustainable energy products such as solar cooking stoves and vendor carts. His innovation team is constantly coming up with new products, like miner's cap lights with solar panels and lights to help women wives and farmers. Hande himself, who has a wife and daughter living in the US for the last 12 years, continues to travel to rural Karnataka, because he feels it is his mission to bring light to people's